

At Wit's End

Academic style lends little to a humourless subject



THE AVADH PUNCH: WIT AND HUMOUR IN COLONIAL NORTH INDIA
by MUSHIRUL HASAN
Niyogi Books
Price: Rs 795; Pages: 176

■ By Dilip Bobb

There wasn't much to laugh about in 19th-century colonial India. Wit and humour were in as short supply as foodgrains and freedom, especially freedom of expression. The title suggests otherwise but is somewhat misleading since it focuses mainly on just one publication, *The Avadh Punch*, and the wit and humour is represented predominantly by a selection of cartoons from the periodical. Published from Lucknow, the weekly, edited by a famous literary figure of the time, Munshi Sajjad Husain, was inspired by, and was almost an exact copy of, the British *Punch*. It was the first Indian publication to feature cartoons and contributed in a major way to satirical writing in Urdu literature. Mushirul Hasan is a well-known academic and historian and consequently, this book is more of an exercise in social study and the recording of cultural history, which means that the subject matter is dry and droll at best.

There is a definite line between wit and satire—and this is more 19th-century Urdu satire, where language was more important than humour. Even the cartoons chosen are illustrations or character sketches, and while they may have contributed to the Urdu literary scene, the cartoonists were wary of insulting their colonial masters, so the caricatures are hardly offensive. They also reflected the weekly's pro-Congress stand, with the result that a majority of the cartoons stuck to Indian subjects and cultural idiosyncrasies. What *The Avadh Punch* did achieve was to create an impressive stable of essayists, poets and cartoonists, most notably the little-known Wilayat Ali Bambooque, whose essays are one of the few bright spots in an otherwise arid, academic effort.

TOP 10 BEST SELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N			
NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (-)	Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows	J.K. Rowling	Bloomsbury
2. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
3. (10)	The Afghan	Frederick Forsyth	Penguin
4. (4)	The Collectors	David Baldacci	MacMillan
5. (15)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Penguin

N O N - F I C T I O N			
NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (-)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost and Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin
3. (3)	It Happened in India	Kishore Biyani, Dipayan Baishya	Rupa
4. (5)	The Last Mughal	William Dalrymple	Penguin
5. (9)	India After Gandhi: The History of the World's Largest Democracy	Ramachandra Guha	Picador

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N			
NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (14)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin
15. (-)	Five Point Someone: What Not to Do at IIT	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa
17. (-)	The Hindi Bindi Club	Monica Pradhan	Penguin

N O N - F I C T I O N			
NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (10)	The Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin S. Sharma	Jaico
7. (11)	The Case of the Bonsai Manager: Lessons from Nature on Growing	R. Gopalakrishnan	Penguin
8. (8)	The Indians: Portrait of a People	Sudhir Kakar and Katharina Kakar	Penguin
9. (2)	In Spite of the Gods	Edward Luce	Penguin

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead